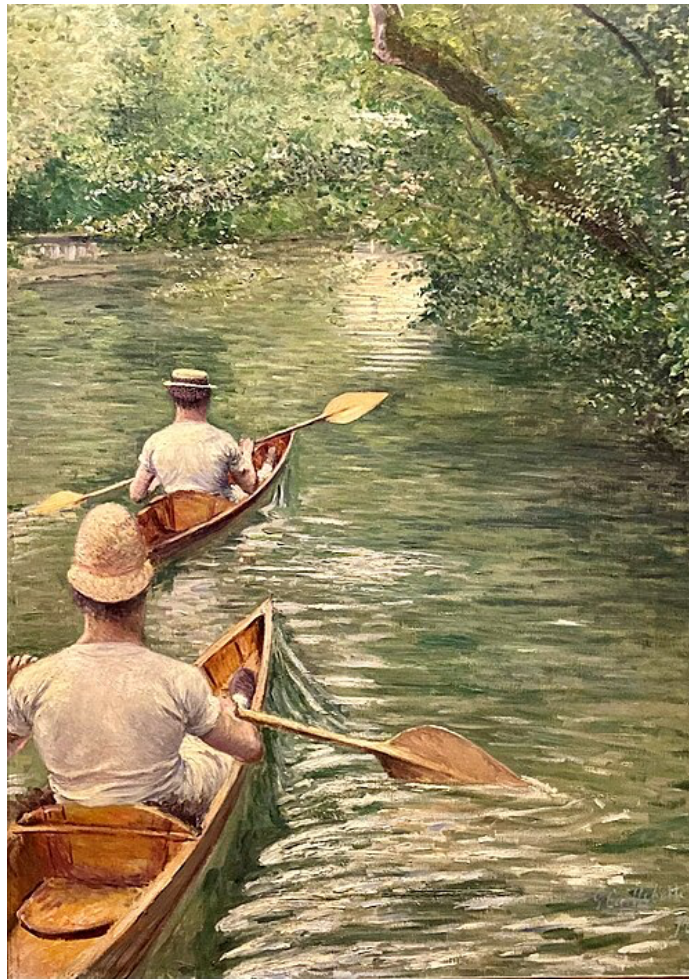


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
How to...Relax*

July 13th, 2025



"The Canoes"
By Gustave Caillebotte, 1878

Above all, trust in the slow work of God. We are quite naturally impatient in everything to reach the end without delay. We would like to skip the intermediate stages. We are impatient of being on the way to something unknown, something new. And yet, it is the law of all progress that it is made by passing through some stages of instability – and that it may take a very long time...

–Pierre Teilhard de Chardin

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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Fantaisie No. 1 in E-flat Major - Camille Saint-Saëns (1835-1921)

Méditation - Maurice Duruflé (1902-1986)

Scherzo - Eugène Gigout (1844-1925)

Choral No. 1 in E Major - César Franck (1822-1890)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Chambers Stevens, Twain Stevens & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Now is the time,
To climb the mountain
And reason against habit,
Now is the time.

Now is the time,
to renew the barren soil of nature
arranged by the winds of tyranny,
Now is the time.

Now is the time,
to commence the litany of hope,
Now is the time...

Now is the time,
to give roses, not to keep them
for graves to come,
give them while our hearts still beat,
give them today
while our hearts yearn for joy,
Now is the time. [adapt/mzwakhe mbuli]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Gather Us In

GATHER US IN

Here in this place, the new light is streaming,
Shadows of doubt are vanished away.
See in this space our fears and our dreamings,
Brought here to you in the light of this day.

Gather us in, the lost and forsaken;
Gather us in; our spirits inflame.
Call to us now, and we shall awaken;
We shall arise at the sound of our name.

We are the young, our lives are a mystery;
We are the old, who yearn for your face.
We have been sung throughout all of history,
Called to be light to the whole human race.
Gather us in, the rich and the haughty;
Gather us in, the proud and the strong;
Give us a heart so meek and so lowly;
Give us the courage to enter the song.

Here we receive new life in the waters;
Here we receive the bread of new birth;
Here you shall call all of your children,
Call us anew to be salt for the earth.
Give us to drink the cup of compassion,
Give us to eat the bread that is you;
Nourish us well, and teach us to fashion
Lives that are holy and hearts that are true.

Not just in buildings, small and confining,
Not in some heaven light years away,
here in this place the new light is shining;
Now is God present, and now is the day.
Gather us in and hold us forever;
Gather us in and make us your own;
Gather us in, all peoples together,
Fire of love in our flesh and our bone.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

God of our yesterdays and God of our tomorrows,
we ask that we feel your presence with us now,
O God, of today.

*Help us in these days of summer
to live with confidence.*

Help us to claim our heritage
with confidence.

*Help us to travel light
carrying what is best from the past to the future.*

God of Vision and New Possibilities
open our hearts and minds to the reality of your presence
this morning.

*As we gather our thoughts in this sacred place,
help us know you are with us in this time,
and in all times and places.*

May your unconditional love flow from us to others
and may the coming days
help us to embrace the Spirit of Life, fully.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

“Three Little Birds”
Laude

BOB MARLEY arr. DAVID HARRIS

***The Lord’s Prayer**

Chambers & Twain Stevens

*Our God, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

All things come from you, O God,
and to you we return.
All things emerge in your great river of life
and into you we vanish again.
At the beginning of this day
we wake
not as separate streams
but as countless currents in a single flow
the flow of this day’s dawning
the flow of this day’s delight
the flow of this day’s sorrows
your flow, O God,
in the twistings and turnings of our days. [jphilipnewell]

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

A Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Book of Ecclesiasticus

Chambers & Twain Stevens

God created human beings out of the earth
and makes us return to it again.
We live within the breadth of the number of our of days
which invites us into relationship with everything that lives.
God blessed us with strength and beauty
and inspires us with everlasting hope.

God placed wisdom within us in our mother's womb
and shows us what is good and what is evil.
God commanded us to love our neighbor
and warns us to follow the law of unity.

Remember that it was of your parents that you were given life.
How can you repay them?
With all your heart honor your family
and do not forget the labor of their love.
Stretch out your hand to the poor
so that you may grow in goodness and generosity.
Give graciously to all the living
and be merciful in how you speak even of those who have died.

Do not avoid those who weep but mourn with those who mourn.
Do not hesitate to visit the sick because for such deeds you will be loved.
In all you do, look to the heart of life and you will be free from great wrongs.
And when you do fail, remember that God encourages all who
are losing hope.
There are new beginnings for those who seek a new way of life.
[jhilipnewell/adptlvf]

These are the Words of Hope.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

We pray:
Illuminating God, each sunrise and sunset
reminds us of your constant presence.
In faith and in love, gathered in this place,
we celebrate the brightness of community
and the summer season.
Praise and wonder be.

God of the lingering sunset and early dawn,
Praise and wonder be.

God of the hot west wind and the refreshing shower,
God of the shady tree and the cool water streams,
God of the ripening harvest and sparkling lakes,
Praise and wonder be.

We have gathered together
conscious that raising our hearts and minds
is a gift of the Spirit of Life at work
in the depths of our being.
*For the presence of that Spirit in us,
we give thanks.*

We have gathered together
conscious that our prayers
give the Spirit a way of breaking into word and song
unique in all the universe.
*For the words and songs within each of us,
we give thanks.*

We have gathered together
mindful of people
throughout human history
who allowed the Spirit of Life
to work in them
for the betterment of our world and humanity.
*For their lives and their inspiration,
we give thanks.*

On this day, Holy One,
we offer our thanks and praise
inviting the Spirit of Life, Love, and Goodness
to move freely in our words and actions.

*On this day, awaken in each of us, Spirit of God,
the possibility for new life, new vision,
and renewed meaning and purpose.* [Watts/lf]

May it be so.
*May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

*When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
How to...Relax*

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

God is within you.

And also in you.

Open your hearts to God's loving presence; trust in the goodness of God.

We open our hearts to the One who is ever present.

Let us give thanks to God,

For God's love has transformed us and made us whole.

We praise you, O God, parent of all creation,

For out of the great expanse of space, you brought light and life,

And called it good.

You are present at the beginning, in the middle, and the end of our times,
so no matter where we are in our journey,

You are there.

Each time we gather at this table, we feel your Spirit of Life
in us and among us.

Make this bread and this cup be for us
a means of transformation and health,
that the Spirit of Wisdom may dwell in us
as a breath of the power of God:
making us an image of God's goodness,
renewing us,
making us friends with God,
that we may in turn befriend
all in need of your justice and love.

We break this bread remembering that
this meal allows us to participate
in the life of the Christ.

We pour this cup grateful for
the ways in which new life is given
through the Christ.

Prayer of Blessing

Divine Presence, in all of life we give thanks
for the gift of love that reaches into our hearts,
for the refreshment of this food that renews us,
for the memories of Jesus and his passion for justice and truth.

At this table, may we be awakened once again,
to live faithfully and boldly,
with deep compassion and integrity
in all times and all places.

[adapt/cheyward-lf]

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Clear Water "
Brandon Harris, Soloist

NADINE SHANTI

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Twain Stevens

Holy One,
with every sunrise and sunset,
help us to know the truth of your love in our lives;
Enable us to grow in the grace we need...
to be agents of change for a better world.
We dedicate ourselves and our gifts
to your dream for our world
on this day – and in all the days to come.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

O God of those who have gone before us,
O God of our children and those still to be born,
O God of creatures and all growing things,
O God of the heavens and the seasons,
of winter's barrenness and spring's energy,
of summer's fruiting and autumn's ripeness,
you are the God of all life.

*May we know you and reverence you in all that lives –
this day and forever more.
Amen.*

[adapt/jphilipnewell]

Choral Response

"A Gaelic Blessing"
Cathedral Choir

JOHN RUTTER

*Hymn for the Journey

Wake Now My Senses

SLANE

Wake, now my senses, and hear the earth call;
Feel the deep power of being in all;
Keep, with the web of creation your vow,
Giving, receiving as love shows us how.

Wake, now my reason, reach out to the new,
Join with each pilgrim who quests for the true;
Honor the beauty and wisdom of time;
Suffer your limit, and praise the sublime.

Wake, now compassion, give heed to the cry;
Voices of suffering fill the wide sky;
Take as your neighbor both stranger and friend,
Praying and striving their hardship to end.

Wake, now my conscience, with justice your guide;
Join with all people whose rights are denied;
Take not for granted a privileged place;
God's love embraces the whole human race.

-lyrics by Mikleson

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Sortie in E-flat Major - Louis Lefébure-Wély (1817-1869)

Inside The Music

"As we explore relaxation this week, much of our music has water-inspired sounds. Nadine Shanti's "Clear Water" that Brandon and Jaebon will offer is a duet with textless voice and piano. Brandon offers the following insight: "'Clear Water' has jazz and classical influences, which is Nadine's style of composition. Nadine uses this piece to showcase the healing and serene qualities water can have. As the chords flow in and out, they represent a river of peace flowing like a healing stream." The textless nature of the piece helps us lean more deeply into the water-like musical imagery. When listening to and watching flowing water, we are met with a human paradox. In an attempt to make meaning of the moment, we often internalize the visual and auditory elements of moving water as singular, or static. The water, however, flows. It's always in motion. The molecules move so fast past us, that we can't even begin to take them in before they are gone. This reality in part makes moving water an apt metaphor for life, or, at least, how we tend to relate to life. We like to consider ourselves and the world around us consistent, even static. Yet, each moment moves so fast that we can't begin to fully identify it before it's gone. Meaning making reflects our capacity to summarize to our best guess what we think might be here tomorrow based on what we've seen in the past. The stream is still there, yes, but the water is long gone. We have the delight of singing one of Jaebon's many choral pieces with her presence on the organ.

“Blessed Are Those Who Trust” draws its text from Jeremiah 17. The central metaphor of the passage is that of a tree growing next to the stream. Because it is well fed, it fears not the draught, and continues to bear fruit. Jaebon’s music flows with a constant 8th note pulse. She uses mixed meter to give the flowing pulse a meandering quality, much like moving water possesses. As the text relates to the tree, the harmonies become more complex and expressive, yet, the flowing water persists. If we are to extend the metaphor of meaning making and reality, perhaps this addition of the tree is as apt as any. Even as the water flows, we can learn to listen to it, feed off of it, and grow strong in its persistent movement through time. We can relax into the reality that change abounds. We can be confident in a trust that extends into the divine, and lets go of the need to count every molecule and moment as they pass.”

– Dr. David Harris

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